

Dancing with the dead

The West African countries of Togo, Ghana, Nigeria, and Benin are the heartlands of Vodun (or Voodoo, see pp.204–207). Vodun is an official religion in Benin, where it has none of the negative connotations attached to Voodoo in the West. Every January, people from across Benin, Togo, and Nigeria descend on the town of Ouidah for Benin's annual festival of worship, which for believers culminates in communion with the dead through trance.

Vodun has a teeming pantheon, all descended from the Supreme Being and creator of the universe, Nana Buluku. His children, Mawu, goddess of the moon, and Lisa, god of the sun, preside over a range of deities and spirits. The most important are Ayida-Weddo, the Rainbow Serpent, mediator between the spirit and living worlds, and Legba, simultaneously old and wise, young and impetuous. Every clan or tribe has its own priestess, presiding over animal sacrifices to appease these spirits. Fetishes—statues and the heads of animals including monkeys, dogs, and cobras—are said to cure ailments and woes.

In the Vodun belief system, ancestors are reached by spirits, and each newborn child is a reincarnation of an ancestor. Trances are thought to enable communication with the world of spirits and ancestors, who then visit earth to possess and guide the living. This member (right) of the Yoruba, a Nigerian ethnic group, enters a trance, brought on by chanting, drumming, and dancing, to take on the power of ancestral spirits.

“Vodun is a way of life in its country of origin, Benin.”

ANISHA SHAH, TRAVEL WRITER, 2017

